1 Introduction

The Copy Theory of Movement holds that the surface forms of movement dependencies are established through a process of Chain Reduction along the PF branch (Chomsky, 1993). In the syntax, on this account, movement simply copies its targets into their derived positions to yield representations like (1a). In the analytical framework that has emerged around this view, these representations acquire their surface forms in the PF-level system of exponence (Halle & Marantz, 1993): at the derivational moment where the terminal nodes of the morphosyntax are given phonological form, lexical content is inserted into a single link to yield the output in (1b) (Saab, 2008, 2017; Muñoz-Pérez, 2018).

(1) *Chain Reduction*

a. SYNTAX: $[_{TP}$ DP AUX $[_{VP}$ VERB DP]].

b. PF: $[_{TP}$ John was $[_{VP}$ seen Δ]].

In the framework of Distributed Morphology (Halle & Marantz, 1993), lexical insertion is standardly positioned at the tail-end of the Morphological Module. This analysis makes it possible to understand how many aspects of Chain Reduction seem to be shaped by the systems of the morphology: for instance, individual links can be modified by morphological operations (Nunes, 2004; Harizanov, 2014a; Baker & Kramer, 2018) and multiple links can undergo insertion to satisfy morphological constraints (Landau, 2006; Jouitteau, 2012). But there are many patterns of Chain Reduction that seem to be shaped by phonological output constraints, which operate in a separate and later module in the standard architecture of DM (Franks, 1999; Bošković, 2001; Bjorkman, 2020). These results raise a network of questions about the structure of PF: what systems guide Chain Reduction, where does insertion occur, and how is information passed between the modules along that branch?

To push forward our understanding of these questions, this paper lays out a system where prosodic constraints derail a preference for insertion into lower positions in a chain. This is one that determines the linear position of the absolutive DP in Mandar, an Austronesian language of Central Indonesia. This language shows a basic word order of VSO and requires every finite clause to host absolutive agreement in T^0. This agreement typically lowers to surface after the highest auxiliary or verb (2a), and in root clauses where non-subjects move to the left periphery, it raises from T^0 to C^0 instead (2b). I will refer to the argument that triggers this agreement as the absolutive DP and underline it throughout.

(2) *Mandar*

a. [$_{TP}$ Nawaca **i** guru <u>buku</u> dionging].
read AGR teacher book yesterday
'The teacher read the book yesterday.'

b. [$_{CP}$ Pirang **i** nawaca <u>buku</u> dionging]?
when AGR read book yesterday
'When did she read the book yesterday?'

The absolutive DP preferentially falls into a three-word window with the host of absolutive agreement. In three-word strings of verbs and arguments, the absolutive DP can always satisfy this constraint from its base position, and as a result, it always surfaces there. But when additional words are introduced across the clause, it is often forced to surface farther to the left to fall into this window—appearing at the edge of the *voice*P (3a) or higher in the extended TP (3b). I will refer to this as ABSOLUTIVE PREPOSING below.

(3) *Absolutive Preposing*

a. [$_{TP}$ Nawaca-waca **i** **<u>buku</u>** guru Δ dionging].
RED-read AGR book teacher yesterday
'The teacher sorta read the book yesterday.'

b. [$_{CP}$ Jas sapa **i** **<u>buku</u>** nawaca Δ manini]?
time what AGR book read later
'What time will they read the book later?'

The first task of the paper is to show that this interaction implicates Chain Reduction: the absolutive DP raises to the edge of the *voice*P and then into the TP in the syntax (4a), it is preferentially exponed in the lowest position along this path (4b), and it is realized higher whenever that allows it to satisfy this constraint (4c). To this end, I first show that the absolutive DP typically undergoes covert A-movement (Potsdam & Polinsky, 2012; Kishimoto, 2013; Deal, 2017): no matter its linear position, it C-commands the ergative DP for the purposes of Variable Binding and Condition C. I then show that independent pressures can force realization of the absolutive DP at the edge of the *voice*P and in a higher position in the TP. These facts reveal that the absolutive DPs which descriptively undergo preposing are simply realized in syntactic positions they move through covertly—rather than undergoing any type of phonological movement that draws them to prosodically-defined positions in service of phonological output constraints (Halpern 1995; Bennett *et al.* 2016; Kusmer 2019; also Richards 2016; Branan 2018; Clemens 2019).

(4) *Variation in Spell-Out*

a. SYNTAX: $[_{TP}$ DP_{ABS} v $[_{voiceP}$ DP_{ABS} DP_{ERG} $[_{voiceP}$ DP_{ABS}]]].

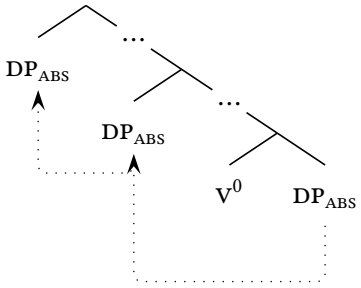
b. USUAL PF: $[_{TP}$ Δ v $[_{voiceP}$ Δ DP_{ERG} $[_{voiceP}$ DP_{ABS}]]].

c. SPECIAL PF: $[_{TP}$ DP_{ABS} v $[_{voiceP}$ Δ DP_{ERG} $[_{voiceP}$ Δ]]].

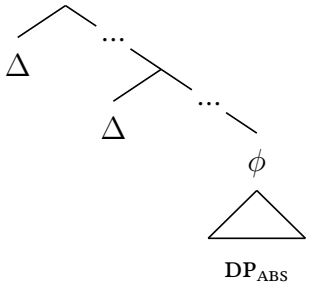
The second task of the paper is to integrate this effect with the architecture of the PF branch. To capture the preference for low insertion, I propose that heads can bear features that mark individual positions as preferential targets for insertion—surfacing low in the Mandar clause to drive low realization in the default case (5a)-(5b). To capture the facts of Absolutive Preposing, I propose that insertion must proceed in the constraint-based and optimizing phonological calculus where prosodic structure is built (Selkirk 2009, 2011). In this module, it is guided by three types of constraints: the pressures that guide Chain Reduction, the pressures that force the faithful execution of instructions from the morphosyntax, and output-oriented phonological constraints. This last family of constraints can outrank and derail the pressure to follow the instructions of the morphosyntax to force Absolutive Preposing: the exceptional realization of higher copies in (5c).

(5) *Chain Reduction*

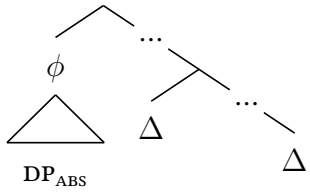
a. *Morphosyntax*



b. *Low Insertion*



c. *High Insertion*

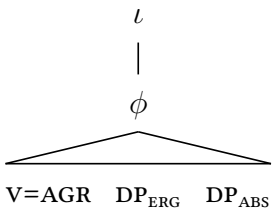


The third task of the paper is to show that the pressure behind Absolutive Preposing is a violable constraint on Prosodic Grouping (Deguchi & Kitagawa 2002; Ishihara 2003; Hirotani 2005; Smith 2005; see also Richards 2016; Branan 2018): one that requires the absolutive DP to fall into a phonological phrase with the exponent of absolutive agreement. When the base position of the absolutive DP falls into a three-word window with the host of absolutive agreement, it is possible to satisfy this constraint by inserting the absolutive DP in the lowest position along its chain (6a). When that position should fall outside of the three-word window with the host of agreement, this constraint disfavors output

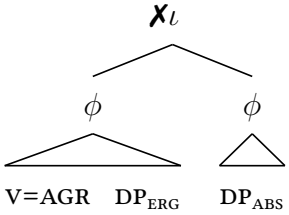
representations like (6b)—and ranked above the pressure to follow the instructions of the morphosyntax, it forces insertion into the next-lowest position along the chain that allows the absolutive DP to satisfy this constraint (6c).

(6) *Output Optimization*

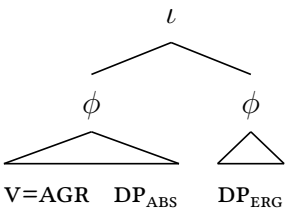
a. *Default Spell-Out*



b. *Prosodic Grouping*



c. *Higher Spell-Out*



The case proceeds in the following way. Section 2 lays out the clausal syntax of Mandar, introduces Absolutive Preposing, and argues that it reduces to variation in Chain Reduction. Section 3 shows that the absolutive DP consistently raises through two positions in the syntax, SPEC,*voice*P and SPEC,ASPP, which are linearly identical to the landing sites of Absolutive Preposing. Section 4 then shows that Absolutive Preposing optimizes for an output constraint and refines the theory of Chain Reduction to capture this effect. Section 5 concludes.

2 Background

Mandar is spoken by roughly 400,000 people in the Indonesian province of West Sulawesi. It belongs to the South Sulawesi Subfamily, a primary branch of Malayo-Polynesian (Esser, 1938; Mills, 1975), and it is the subject of several descriptive works by the Language Office of South Sulawesi (Pelenkahu *et al.*, 1983; Sikki *et al.*, 1987; Muthalib & Sangi, 1991). This paper describes standard Mandar, which is spoken along the south coast of West Sulawesi (Grimes & Grimes, 1987). It presents data gathered primarily in elicitation with Jupri Talib, a speaker whom I have worked with since 2018. This data has been cross-checked over regular trips to the field by interaction with the wider community and explicit verification with two native speaker linguists, Sitti Sapiah and Hairuddin. I believe that it is representative of standard Mandar and replicable in many dialects and languages nearby.[1]

[1] GLOSSES: ABS: absolutive, ANTIP: antipassive, APPL: applicative, ERG: ergative, GEN: genitive

2.1 Clause Structure

Mandar shows a basic order of V-EXT-INT-GOAL (verb > external argument > internal argument > applied argument). The order of postverbal arguments is rigid in verb-initial clauses where the VERB-ARGUMENT-ARGUMENT string contains exactly three prosodic words. In that context, the EXT must precede the INT (7a) and the EXT and INT must precede the GOAL (7b). The constituents that form prosodic words are verbs, nouns, adverbs, and the preverbal auxiliaries that host absolutive agreement.

(7) *The Mandar Clause*

a. Na-ita i [$_{vP}$ **dottor** **guru**] dionging.
3ERG-see 3ABS doctor teacher yesterday.
'The doctor saw the teacher yesterday.'

b. U-yolo-ang i [$_{vP}$ **dottor** **guru**] dionging.
1ERG-show-APPL 3ABS doctor teacher yesterday
'I showed the doctor to the teacher yesterday.'

The language has preverbal auxiliaries that mark distinctions of polarity, tense, modality, and aspect (Brodkin, 2026b).[2] The highest auxiliary hosts absolutive agreement, which typically forms portmanteaux with clitics that mark viewpoint aspect (8a). In clauses that lack auxiliaries, absolutive agreement and the viewpoint aspect clitics follow the verb (8b).

(8) *Preverbal Auxiliaries*

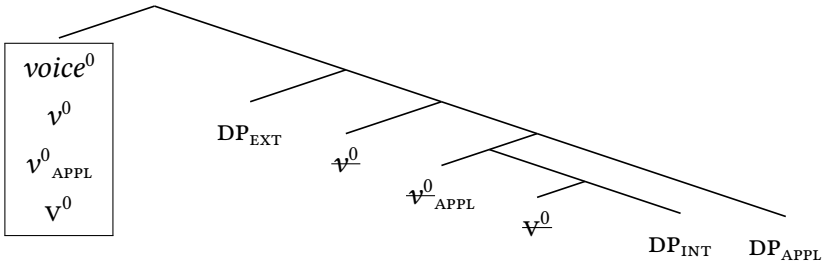
a. [$_{\Sigma P}$ Rua mi [$_{voiceP}$ u-ita setang dio]].
have 3ABS.NOW 1ERG-see demon there
'Now I've seen the demon there.'

b. [$_{\Sigma P}$ U-ita mi [$_{voiceP}$ setang dio]].
1ERG-see 3ABS.NOW demon there
'Now I see the demon there.'

[2] The class of auxiliaries includes *ndang* "not," *da* "don't," *pura* "PAST," *na* "FUT," *mala* "can," *pali* "have time to," *byasa* "usually," *rua* "have," *yari* "COMPLETIVE," and *lesse'* "INCOMPLETIVE." Five properties distinguish them from various types of preverbal adverbs in the language: they are rigidly ordered, they typically fail to form words, they can license VPE, the highest auxiliary hosts absolutive agreement, and in polar questions, the highest auxiliary raises to C^0. On similar auxiliaries in Indonesian, see Fortin 2007a,b; Arka 2013; Jeoung 2020; Vander Klok & Paul 2021: in Javanese, Vander Klok 2008, 2013a,b, 2015, 2017.

The verb reaches its high position through two distinct sequences of head movement. First, it raises to the head at the top of the extended VP, which I take to be *voice*^{0}, and lands just above the head that introduces the EXT, which I take to be v^0 (following the labels in Collins 2005; Merchant 2013). This process amalgamates it with applicative suffixes that surface on ditransitive verbs, which realize a low applicative head (Pylkkänen, 2008), and transitivity suffixes that surface after certain roots, which realize v^0 (Brodkin, 2026a).

(9) *Movement to Voice*



Second, the verb typically raises into the extended TP to a head that marks polarity: Σ^0 (Laka, 1990, 1993; Zanuttini, 1997). This process applies in clauses that lack auxiliaries (10a). In clauses that contain auxiliaries, the highest auxiliary raises to Σ^0 instead (10b).

(10) *Movement to Polarity*

a. [$_{\Sigma P}$ U-ita i [$_{voiceP}$ __ dottor dionging]].
1ERG-see 3ABS doctor yesterday
'I saw the doctor yesterday.'

b. [$_{\Sigma P}$ Ndang i yari [$_{voiceP}$ u-ita dottor dionging]].
not 3ABS COMPLETE 1ERG-see doctor yesterday
'I didn't see the doctor yesterday.'

Absolutive agreement originates above Σ^0 and the viewpoint aspect clitics in ASP^0 VIEW. I propose that it sits in T^0 and typically lowers to Σ^0 in the postsyntax, forcing it to follow the highest auxiliary or the raised verb (Brodkin 2022; see also Finer 1997, 1999; Béjar 1999 on the related Selayarese and, for subfamily-level discussion, Kaufman 2008). As noted above, I will underline the DP that triggers this agreement and call it the absolutive DP.

(11) *Postsyntactic Lowering*

[$_{TP}$ T^0 [$_{ASPP}$ ASP^0 [$_{\Sigma P}$ VERB ___ …]]]

2.2 High Absolutive Syntax

Transitive and ditransitive verbs host ergative agreement with the EXT. This agreement is strictly preverbal, it never surfaces on auxiliaries, and it appears in structurally reduced clauses that lack T^0. On many roots, it occurs alongside the transitivity-marking suffix *-í*.

(12) *Transitive and Ditransitive Morphology*

a. Pura i **u**-timbang-ngi i do'ayu digena'.
PAST 3ABS 1ERG-weigh-TRANSITIVE water earlier
'I weighed the vegetables earlier.'

b. Pura i **u**-timbang-ang-ngi do'ayu digena'.
PAST 3ABS 1ERG-weigh-APPL-TRANSITIVE vegetable earlier
'I weighed the vegetables for them earlier.'

Ergative agreement surfaces in complementary distribution with affixes that trace argument structure alternations in the extended VP. It is absent from passive verbs, which retain the transitivity suffix (13a). It is also absent from antipassive verbs, which lack the transitivity suffix and host prefixes that show allomorphy conditioned by the root (13b).[3]

(13) *The Voice System*

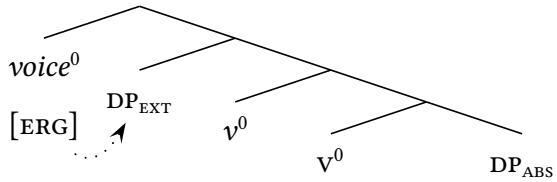
a. **Di**-gallogallo-i a' yau digena'.
PASS-bother-TRANSITIVE 1ABS I earlier
'I was bothered earlier.'

b. **Mang**-gallogallo a' yau dottor digena'.
ANTIP-bother 1ABS I doctor earlier
'I was bothering doctors earlier.'

[3]The Mandar antipassive is cognate to the category identified in traditional Austronesian terms as the "Agent Voice" (Kroeger, 1993; Aldridge, 2004; Paul & Travis, 2006). Mandar antipassive verbs require their internal and applied arguments to be indefinite and allows them both to be freely omitted (presumably in a type of indefinite argument ellipsis). These arguments are not visibly marked for demotion, in keeping with the head-marking character of the language, but the antipassive construction is morphologically intransitive—in the sense that it requires the external argument to trigger absolutive agreement. For comparative discussion across South Sulawesi, see Strømme 1994; Valkama 1995; Jukes 2006; for discussion across Western Austronesian, see Aldridge 2011, 2012. On the link from antipassive morphology to progressive aspect or atelicity, which is present in Mandar in some form, see especially Soh & Nomoto 2009. For specific discussion of ergative and absolutive agreement across South Sulawesi, see Kaufman 2008.

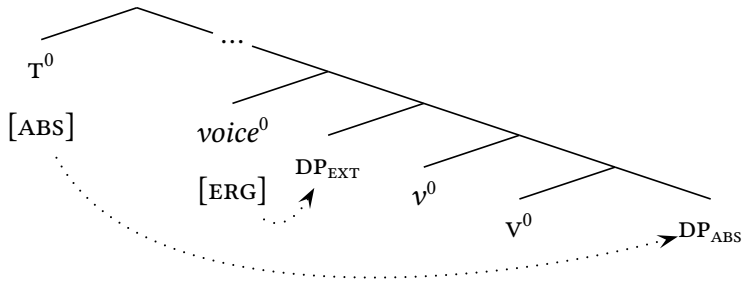
This type of voice morphology is distributed across a string of heads in the extended VP.[4] (Brodkin, 2022) argues that ergative agreement originates in *voice*^{0}, which agrees with the EXT (in the sense of Chomsky 2001) when the verb is transitive or ditransitive. This step licenses the EXT with abstract Case (Vergnaud, 1977): more specifically, this *voice*^{0} assigns Low Ergative Case to the EXT in SPEC,*v*P (Aldridge 2004; Wiltschko 2006).

(14) *Ergative Agreement*



Extending the link from agreement to Licensing, Brodkin 2022 proposes that the Mandar absolutive DP receives Case from T^0 (on this link see Raposo 1987). The result is a High Absolutive system of Case-assignment (Bittner & Hale 1996b,a; also Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992): the highest source of structural Case falls to the argument that is underlyingly second-highest in the *voice*P. When the verb is transitive, this argument is INT; when it is ditransitive, it is the GOAL. The A-syntax skips the EXT in each case because it is INACTIVE (Chomsky, 2001) and thus ignored by the probes that drive A-movement and ϕ-agreement.

(15) *High Absolutive Licensing*

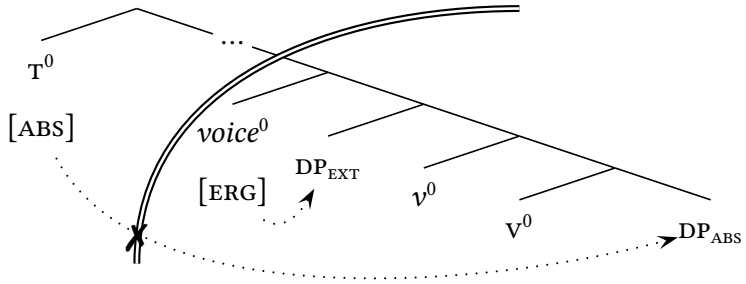


If the Mandar *voice*P defines a phase, this analysis raises a puzzle of absolute locality. I propose that the clause-internal phase is opaque to external probes in Mandar: heads in the extended TP can only interact with arguments at the edge of the *voice*P (Chomsky 2001;

[4] There are morphological differences between the Mandar voice system and its analogues across Western Indonesia: ergative agreement, for instance, is absent from the analogous transitive construction outside South Sulawesi (the "Patient Voice"). In the syntax, however, the morphology of the Austronesian voice system is likely distributed across heads in the extended VP in many other languages of the area: for instance, Malay and Indonesian (Nomoto, 2013) and their closest relatives (Erlewine & Sommerlot, 2025)).

cf. Bošković 2007). When T^0 probes to trigger agreement, on this view, it should never be able to reach the *v*P (Aldridge, 2004; Coon *et al.*, 2014; Nomoto, 2013). In transitive and ditransitive clauses, we thus have to ask: how can T^0 interact with the INT and the GOAL?

(16) *Phase-Based Locality*



2.3 The Three-Word Window

To tackle this question, we can turn to a PF constraint that influences the linear position of the absolutive DP. In Mandar, there is a ranked and violable pressure to realize the absolutive DP in a contiguous three-word string with the constituent that hosts absolutive agreement (17). I will refer to this pressure as the *Grouping Constraint*.

(17) *The Grouping Constraint* (First Pass)
The entire absolutive DP is preferentially realized in a three-word window with the constituent that hosts absolutive agreement (which is an enclitic).

In clauses that contain three words (ignoring final adjuncts to the *voice*P), the absolutive DP can always satisfy this constraint from its base position in the *v*P. In three-word strings where absolutive agreement follows a transitive verb, for instance, the absolutive INT can fit into a window with the verb and a preceding EXT (18a). In three-word strings where the verb is ditransitive, the absolutive GOAL can fit into a window with the verb and a preceding EXT or INT (18b). I will mark this three-word window with braces below.

(18) *Absolutive Arguments: Regular Order*

a. {$_\phi$ Na-báca i gúru **búku** } dionging.
3ERG-read 3ABS teacher book yesterday
'The teacher read the book yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ Na-báca-ngang i búku **gúru** } dionging.
3ERG-read-APPL 3ABS book teacher yesterday
'They read the book to the teacher yesterday.'

2.4 Absolutive Preposing

In clauses that contain additional words, the base positions of individual arguments are often excluded from this window. When the verb is ditransitive, for instance, the INT can be excluded if additional words are added in the verbal complex (19a) or in the EXT (19b).

(19) *Expulsion from the Window*

a. {$_\phi$ **Na-báca-báca-ngang** a' gúru } búku diónging.
3ERG-RED-read-APPL 1ABS teacher book yesterday
'The teacher sorta read me the book yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ Na-báca-ngang a' **gúru linguístik** } búku diónging.
3ERG-read-APPL 1ABS teacher linguistic book yesterday
'The linguistics teacher read me the book yesterday.'

When the INT is absolutive in strings of this type, it cannot surface in its base position: in four-word strings that begin with transitive verbs, the INT cannot follow the EXT. We see this effect whenever the INT contains one word and the verb and the EXT amount to three: for instance, when the verb is reduplicated (20a) or the EXT hosts an adjective (20b).

(20) *Grouping Violations*

a. {$_\phi$ ***Na-báca-báca** i gúru } <u>búku</u> diónging.
3ERG-RED-read 3ABS teacher book yesterday
'The teacher sorta read the book yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ *Na-báca i **gúru linguístik** } <u>búku</u> diónging.
3ERG-read 3ABS teacher linguistic book yesterday
'The linguistics teacher read the book yesterday.'

The following examples show the repair to this constraint: the INT is forced to surface in a derived position that precedes the EXT and follows the raised verb. I will refer to this process as Absolutive Preposing and mark the position it escapes with the symbol Δ.

(21) *Absolutive Preposing*

a. {$_\phi$ **Na-báca-báca** i <u>búku</u> } gúru Δ diónging.
3ERG-RED-read 3ABS book teacher yesterday
'The teacher sorta read the book yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ Na-báca i <u>búku</u> } **gúru linguístik** Δ diónging.
3ERG-read 3ABS book teacher linguistic yesterday
'The linguistics teacher read the book yesterday.'

Absolutive Preposing is governed by the Grouping Constraint: it occurs exactly and only when the absolutive DP can only fit into its window from a derived position. In three-word strings where the absolutive INT can satisfy the Grouping Constraint from its base position, the absolutive INT cannot undergo preposing (22a). In clauses where the absolutive DP contains too many words to fit into a window with the host of agreement, Absolutive Preposing is blocked in the same way. In verb-initial clauses, as a result, the absolutive DP takes its base position whenever it contains three words (22b).[5]

(22) *Constraints on Preposing*

a. {$_\phi$ Na-íta i dóttor **gúru** } dionging.
3ERG-read 3ABS doctor teacher yesterday

RIGID VSO READING: 'The doctor saw the teacher yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ Na-íta i dóttor } **gúru** **ílmu** **bása** dionging.
3ERG-read 3ABS doctor teacher science language yesterday

RIGID VSO READING 'The doctor saw the language science teacher yesterday.'

The Grouping Constraint requires the three-word window to contain the complete absolutive DP. It is not satisfied in contexts that only allow the window to contain subparts of the absolutive DP. As a result, the language prohibits four-word strings that contain a one-word verb, a one-word intervening argument, and a two-word absolutive DP (23a). In these environments, the absolutive DP invariably undergoes Absolutive Preposing (23b).

(23) *Exhaustive Parsing*

a. {$_\phi$ *Na-báca i gúru **búku** } **linguístik** diónging.
3ERG-read 3ABS teacher book linguistics yesterday

INTENDED: 'The teacher read the linguistics book yesterday.'

b. {$_\phi$ Na-báca i **búku** **linguístik** } gúru Δ diónging.
3ERG-read 3ABS book linguistics teacher yesterday

'The teacher read the linguistics book yesterday.'

The result is an interaction shaped by information of two types: the distribution of postsyntactic constituents in the surface phonology (prosodic words and phonological phrases) and the syntactic identity of the absolutive DP and T^0. Its effect is stated in (24).

[5]More generally, Absolutive Preposing is banned when the absolutive DP and the host of agreement collectively contain more than three words. It is impossible when the absolutive DP and the host of agreement each contain two or when the absolutive DP contains one and the host of agreement contains three.

(24) *Absolutive Preposing* (First Pass)

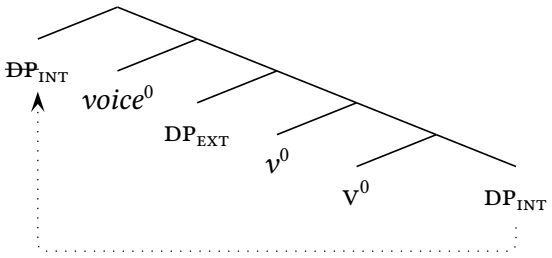
The entire absolutive DP is preferentially realized in a three-word window with the constituent that hosts absolutive agreement. If it can satisfy that constraint from its base position, it is realized there. If it can only satisfy that constraint at the edge of the *voice*P, it is realized there. Otherwise, it is realized in its base position.

2.5 Covert A-Movement

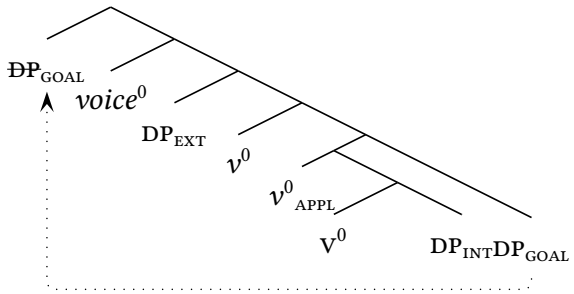
To capture this effect, I propose that the Mandar absolutive DP consistently moves in the syntax to the edge of the *voice*P. This process is driven by an A-probe on $voice^0$ that skips the EXT to target the next-highest DP in the *v*P. The result is that the Mandar absolutive DP is a type of phrase-structural subject: it always moves to the highest derived A-position in the clause and receives the highest source of structural Case (Guilfoyle *et al.*, 1992).

(25) *Absolutive Movement*

a. *Transitive VoiceP*



b. *Ditransitive VoiceP*



In the default case, I propose that this step of A-movement is covert (Potsdam & Polinsky 2012; Polinsky & Potsdam 2013; Kishimoto 2013; Deal 2017). Adopting the Copy Theory of Movement, I assume that there is no difference in the syntax between movements that are overt and covert (Bobaljik, 1995, 2002). When the absolutive DP is targeted for attraction by $voice^0$, on this view, it does not leave behind any type of trace—instead, it remains in its base position and a copy of that constituent is introduced in SPEC,*voice*P.

(26) *Movement = Copying*

a. COPYING: $[_{voiceP}\ DP_{ABS}\ \ voice^0\ \ [_{vP}\ DP_{ERG}\ \ [_{VP}\ DP_{ABS}\ ]\ ]\ ].$

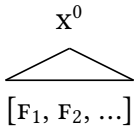
b. REJECTED: $[_{voiceP}\ DP_{ABS}\ \ voice^0\ \ [_{vP}\ DP_{ERG}\ \ [_{VP}\ t\ \ ]\ ]\ ].$

Adopting the rough architecture of Distributed Morphology, I propose that Chain Reduction involves a failure of exponence (Saab, 2008, 2017; Muñoz-Pérez, 2018). Adopting

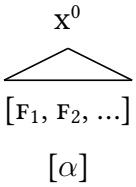
a theory of Late Insertion, I assume that the terminal nodes of the morphosyntax acquire phonological content in the postsyntax through a process of Vocabulary Insertion (Embick 2015). I take this process to proceed in two steps (see also Bye & Svenonius 2012; Kalin 2022; Hewett & Kramer 2026). First, the postsyntax matches terminal nodes with exponents at a stage that follows morphological operations like impoverishment and linearization (Halle & Marantz, 1993; Adger, 2006; Arregi & Nevins, 2012; Hewett, 2023). Second, it inserts the exponents it selects in a derivationally later step.

(27) *Insertion and Exponence*

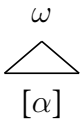
a. *Feature Bundles*



b. *Matching*



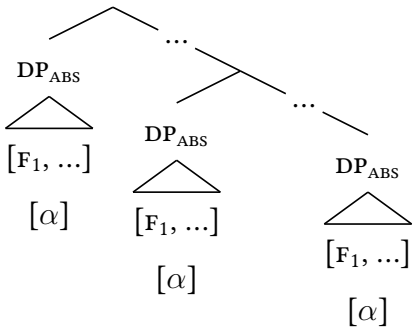
c. *Insertion*



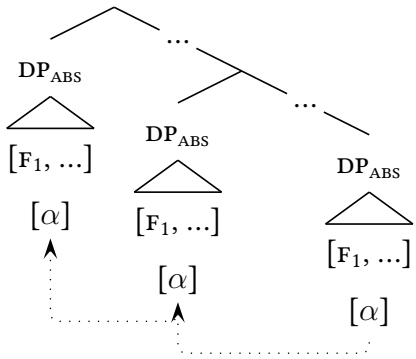
I propose that insertion follows a morphological process of Chain Formation that inspects syntactic representations like (28a) to group syntactic copies into chains like (28b) (Muñoz-Pérez, 2018). Chain Reduction is forced at the stage of insertion by the interaction of two constraints: PF-RECOVERABILITY, a MAX constraint that demands a unique output exponent for every input chain, and PF-ECONOMY, a DEP constraint that demands a unique input chain for every output exponent (see also Pesetsky 1997; Landau 2006).

(28) *Chain Formation*

a. *Global Inspection*



b. *Chain Formation*

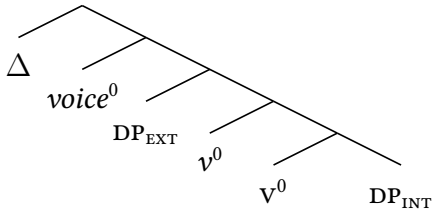


In the Mandar *voice*P, Chain Reduction favors insertion into the lowest copy of the absolutive DP. When left unchecked, this preference forces lower-copy spell-out (29a). When it would induce violations of the Grouping Constraint, however, the absolutive DP

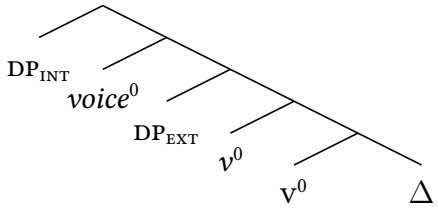
is realized in SPEC,*voice*P (29b). The result is an interaction between Chain Reduction and a PF-constraint.[6]

(29) *Chain Reduction*

a. *Low Spell-Out*

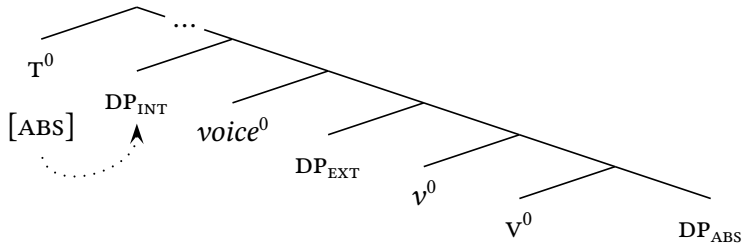


b. *High Spell-Out*



This analysis resolves the puzzle of absolute locality: in Mandar, the absolutive DP is accessible to the heads of the extended TP because it raises to the edge of the *voice*P. It also allows us to situate Mandar within a class of languages that show movement of this type—one which includes many of its relatives in the Western Austronesian region (Aldridge 2004, 2008, 2012; Nomoto 2013; Erlewine 2018; Erlewine & Sommerlot 2025).[7]

(30) *External Accessibility*



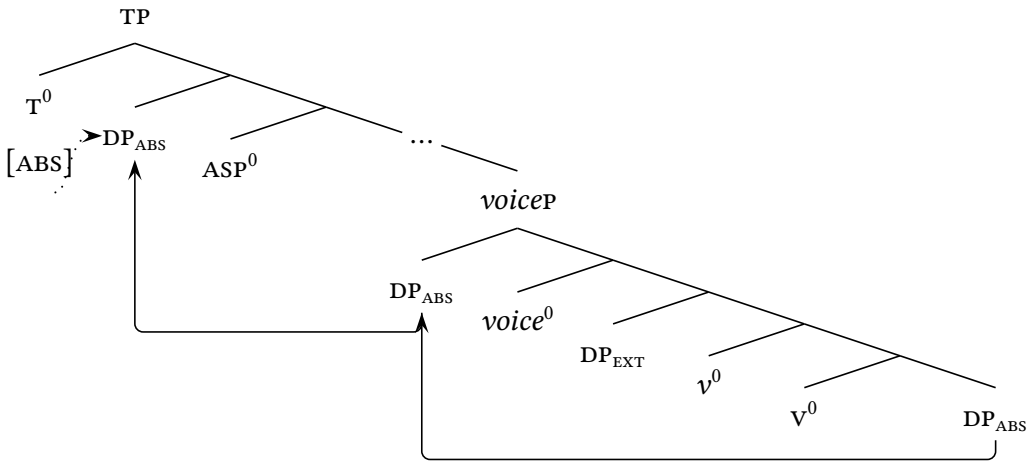
[6]Similar effects are forced by many types of PF constraints: morphological restrictions on adjacency (which blocks overt object shift in Scandinavian (Bobaljik, 2002), subject raising in Greek (Spyropoulos & Revithiadou, 2007), and A-movement under passivization in Inuktitut (Yuan, 2025)), haplology constraints (which block overt WH-movement in Romanian (Bošković, 2002)), and phonological constraints (which block overt movement of pronouns and auxiliaries in South Slavic (Franks, 1998; Bošković, 2001)).

[7]On this perspective, Mandar shares three properties with other Western Austronesian languages at the level of the *voice*P. First, it provides no structural case for the argument that will become the absolutive DP (like other High Absolutive languages, in other words, it does not allow the transitive v^0 to assign accusative Case to the INT; Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992). Second, it provides structural case for all other arguments in that domain (like other High Absolutive languages, it furnishes a low source of Ergative Case for the transitive EXT; see also Nomoto 2013; Erlewine & Sommerlot 2025). Third, it requires the absolutive DP to raise to the edge of the clause-internal phase (Aldridge, 2004). For comparable analyses of High Absolutive configurations outside this region, see Bittner & Hale 1996a,b; Coon *et al.* 2014; for alternative theories of Austronesian, see Rackowski 2002; Pearson 2005; Chen 2017; for discussion of Selayarese, Finer 1994, 1997.

3 Identifying Covert Movement

The case for this analysis flows from two interlocking arguments about the absolutive DP. First, I claim that it systematically raises along the path in (31): moving first to SPEC,*voice*P and then to a higher A-position in the extended TP.[8] Second, I claim that the positions it takes to satisfy the Grouping Constraint correspond exactly to SPEC,*voice*P and its higher A-position in the TP. These results make it possible to understand the linear effect of Absolutive Preposing as a consequence of Chain Reduction along the PF branch.

(31) *The Path of the Absolutive DP*



3.1 Binding Evidence

Mandar has a class of reduced clauses selected by the P⁰ *mau* "though" which I will refer to as though-complements. Though-complements are typically ΣPs: they lack absolutive agreement and viewpoint aspect, but they can host auxiliaries and show V-raising to Σ⁰.

[8] On this analysis, the verb-initial word order of the language is a surface-level fact: in the syntax, Mandar requires the absolutive DP to raise into the middle field and move past the final position of the verb. In regional perspective, this analysis places Mandar in a syntactic class with the SVO languages of Western Indonesia, which require visible movement of the pivot into the middle field. In verb-initial languages that show regular and covert A-movement of the absolutive DP, the absolutive DP is typically assumed to raise only to the edge of the clause-internal phase (Aldridge 2004, 2008; Erlewine 2018; also Coon *et al.* 2014; Royer 2025 on Mayan). In wider perspective, the Mandar facts may lend credence to proposals which posit higher movement in other languages of this type (e.g., Guilfoyle *et al.* 1992). It also reinforces the analytical claim that high absolutive arguments are structurally equivalent to nominative subjects: they can be raised beyond the edge of the clause-internal phase in response to the idiosyncratic distribution of movement-driving features on the heads of the extended TP (Cable, 2012; Zyman, 2018).

(32) *Though-Complements*

a. **Mau** [$_{\Sigma P}$ ndang rua [$_{voiceP}$ na-ita dio di perpus]],
though not ever 3ERG-see there in library
'Though never seen in the library,'

b. **Mau** [$_{\Sigma P}$ na-ita [$_{voiceP}$ ___ dio di perpus]],
though 3ERG-see there in library
'Though seen in the library,'

Though-complements can contain overt absolutive DPs. I assume that these absolutive DP are licensed by the subordinating P^0 in this context, rather than any type of null T^0. The Grouping Constraint is not enforced in the absence of T^0, so in though-complements, the absolutive DP is always realized in its base position. When the verb is transitive, the INT follows the EXT (33a); when the verb is ditransitive, the GOAL follows the INT (33b).

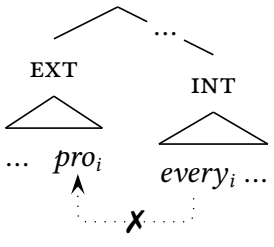
(33) *Absolutive Arguments without Agreement*

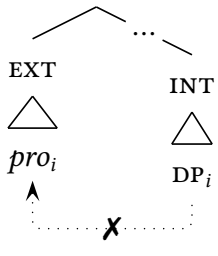
a. **Mau** na-ita guru linguistik **dottor** dio,
though 3ERG-see teacher linguistics doctor there
'Though the linguistics teacher saw the doctor there,'

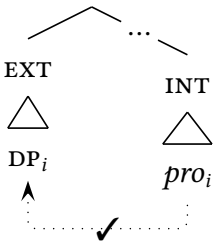
b. **Mau** na-be-ngang guru buku **dottor** dio,
though 3ERG-give-APPL teacher book doctor there
'Though the teacher gave the book to the doctor there,'

In this context, we can detect covert A-movement of the absolutive DP from the facts of variable binding and pronominal coreference (Brodkin, 2022). In ditransitive constructions where the INT is oblique, we see interactions between the EXT and the INT that trace the effects of Conditions B and C (Chomsky, 1981; Reinhart, 1983): the INT cannot bind into the EXT (34a), it cannot contain an R-expression coindexed with a pronominal EXT (34b), and it can be a pronoun coindexed with an R-expression in the EXT (34c).

(34) *Oblique Internal Arguments*

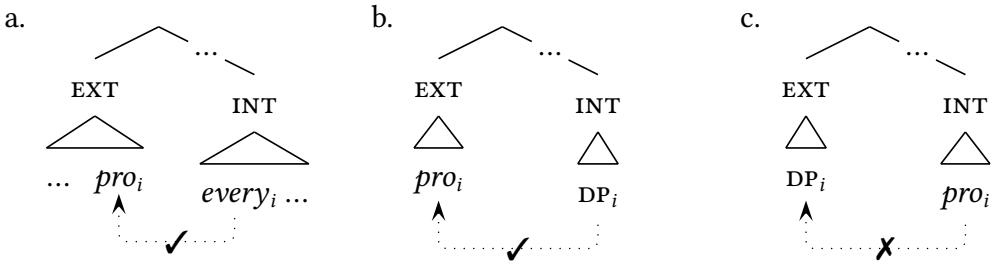
a.


b.


c.


When the verb is transitive and the INT is absolutive, the INT gains the ability to bind into the EXT (35a) and contain R-expressions coindexed with a pronominal EXT (35b) and loses the ability to be a pronoun coindexed with an R-expression in the EXT (35c).

(35) *Absolutive Internal Arguments*



The following examples introduce the initial constraint on variable binding. When the EXT contains a pronoun, a quantified INT cannot bind it when the INT is not the absolutive DP (36a). When the INT is the absolutive DP, however, it can (36b).

(36) *Variable Binding*

a. Mau na-kiring-ang panulis-na buku nasang **mai** dionging,
though 3ERG-send-APPL author-its book every to me yesterday
'Though its$_i$ author sent me every book$_{*i,k}$ book yesterday,'

b. Mau na-kiring panulis-na **buku nasang** dionging,
though 3ERG-send author-its book every yesterday
'Though its$_i$ author sent every book$_{i,j}$ yesterday,'

We can replicate this effect with the first constraint on pronominal coreference. When the EXT is a pronoun, the INT cannot contain a coreferential R-expression when it is not the absolutive DP (37a). When the INT is the absolutive DP, however, it can (37b).

(37) *Condition C: Part One*

a. Mau na-jolo-ang ***pro*** buku-nna guru mai dionging,
though 3ERG-show-APPL he book-of teacher to me yesterday
'Though he$_i$ showed me the teacher$_{*i,j}$'s books yesterday,'

b. Mau na na-baca ***pro*** [$_{INT}$ buku na-alli guru digena'] manini,
though FUTURE 3ERG-read he book 3ERG-buy teacher earlier later
'Though he$_i$ will read the book the teacher$_{i,j}$ bought earlier later,'

We see the same effects with the second constraint on pronominal coreference. When the INT is a pronoun, it can co-refer with an R-expression in the EXT when the INT is not the absolutive DP (38a). When the INT is the absolutive DP, however, it cannot (38b).

(38) *Condition C: Part Two*

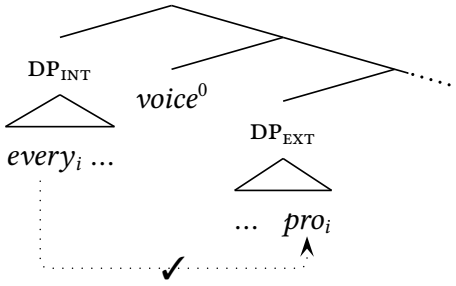
a. Mau na-jolo-ang sola-na guru ***pro*** mai dionging,
though 3ERG-show-APPL friend-of teacher him to me yesterday
'Though the teacher$_i$'s friends showed him$_{i,j}$ to me yesterday,'

b. Mau na-ita [$_{EXT}$ sola-na guru na dottor] ***pro*** dionging,
though 3ERG-see friend-of teacher and doctor him yesterday
'Though the teacher$_i$ and the doctor's friends saw him$_{*i,j}$ yesterday,'

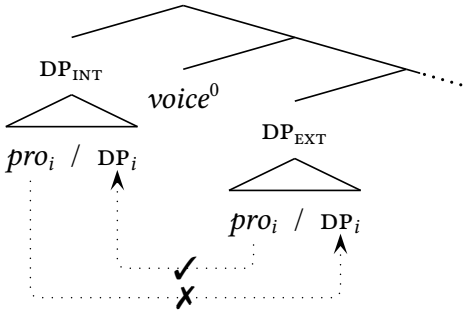
These effects follow from A-movement to SPEC,*voice*P: movement of the absolutive INT licenses the variable binding in (39a) and sets up the coreference constraints in (39b).

(39) *Movement to SPEC,VoiceP*

a. *Variable Binding*



b. *Condition C*



3.2 Overt Movement to SPEC,*Voice*P

Alongside postnominal quantifiers like *nasang*, Mandar has a second class of prenominal quantifiers that includes *ianasanna* "each," *inggannanna* "all," *mai'di* "many," *sicco'* "few," and numerals and classifiers of various types (Brodkin, 2025a).

(40) *Prenominal Quantifiers*

a. Mau sita guru [sola sanaeke **nasang**] dionging,
though meet teacher with kid every yesterday
'Though the teacher met with every kid yesterday,'

b. Mau sita guru [sola **ianasanna** sanaeke] dionging,
though meet teacher with each kid yesterday
'Though the teacher met with each kid yesterday,'

In though-complements where prenominal quantifiers appear in the absolutive DP, the absolutive DP is realized in a linear position that corresponds to SPEC,*voice*P. When the

verb raises to Σ^0, it appears immediately after the verb (41a). When the verb remains in *voice*^{0} in the presence of auxiliaries, it appears immediately before the verb (41b).[9]

(41) *Movement to* SPEC,*voice*P

a. Mau na-nilai [$_{voiceP}$ **inggannanna** **ujiang** __ guru Δ] sangallo,
though 3ERG-grade all test teacher in a day
'Though the teacher graded all the tests in a day,'

b. Mau rua [$_{voiceP}$ **inggannanna** **ujiang** na-nilai Δ] sangallo,
though once all test 3ERG-grade in a day
'Though she once graded all the tests in a day,'

This position is linearly identical to the landing site of Absolutive Preposing that we saw in Section 2. When the verb raises to Σ^0, the Grouping Constraint can force regular absolutive DPs to surface just after the verb (42a). When the verb remains in *voice*^{0}, however, it is impossible for the absolutive DP to surface in the same linear position (42b).

(42) *Absolutive Preposing Beneath Auxiliaries*

a. {$_{\phi}$ **Na-báca-báca** i búku } gúru Δ diónging.
3ERG-RED-read 3ABS book teacher yesterday
'The teacher sorta read the book yesterday.'

b. {$_{\phi}$ *__Rúa__ i na-báca búku } gúru Δ dirambóngi.
once 3ABS 3ERG-read book teacher in the past
INTENDED: 'The teacher once read the book in the past.'

When the Grouping Constraint forces Absolutive Preposing in auxiliary-initial clauses, the absolutive DP is forced to linearly precede the verb in *voice*^{0}. The following examples

[9] It is impossible for the absolutive DPs that contain prenominal quantifiers to surface in any other position in strings of this type. When the verb raises to Σ^0, they cannot precede the verb (1a). When the verb remains in *voice*^{0}, they cannot follow it (1b). They are also unable to take their base positions in the *v*P.

(1) *Movement to* SPEC,*voice*P

a. *Mau **inggannanna** **ujiang** na-nilai [$_{voiceP}$ ___ guru Δ] sangallo,
though all test 3ERG-grade teacher in a day
INTENDED: 'Though the teacher graded all the tests in a day,'

b. *Mau rua [$_{voiceP}$ na-nilai **inggannanna** **ujiang** guru Δ] sangallo,
though once 3ERG-grade all test teacher in a day
INTENDED: 'Though the teacher once graded all the tests in a day,'

illustrate this effect. When absolutive agreement lowers to follow an auxiliary, it forces the auxiliary to form a word (a prosodic subcategorization effect; Brodkin 2026b). In three-word strings where the absolutive DP can fall into a window with this auxiliary from its base position, the absolutive DP is realized there (43a). In four-word strings where the absolutive DP cannot, it follows the lowest auxiliary and precedes the verb instead (43b)

(43) *Absolutive Preposing: SPEC,voiceP*

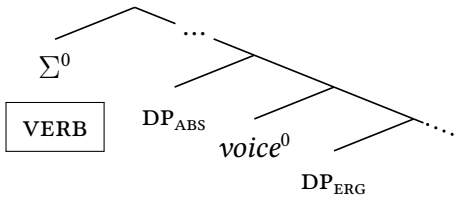
a. {$_{\phi}$ Ndáng i rua na-báca **búku** } diónging.
not 3ABS ever 3ERG-read book yesterday
'She never read the book yesterday.'

b. {$_{\phi}$ Ndáng i rua **búku** na-báca } guru Δ diónging.
not 3ABS ever book 3ERG-read teacher yesterday
'The teacher never read the book yesterday.'

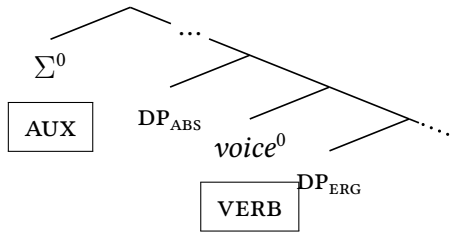
I propose that both of these linear alternations reflect exceptional spell-out in SPEC,*voice*P. This position follows the verb and precedes the EXT when the verb raises to Σ^0 (44a). When the verb remains in *voice*^{0}, it follows every auxiliary and precedes the verb (44b).

(44) *Movement to SPEC,voiceP*

a.



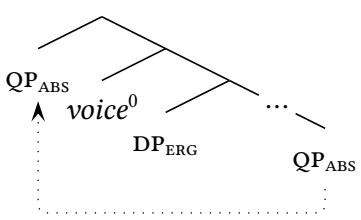
b.



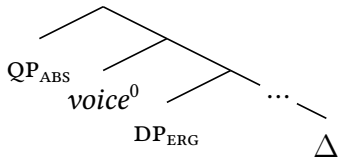
On this analysis, prenominal quantifiers have no effect on the external syntax of the absolutive DP, which always raises to SPEC,*voice*P. The linear alternations that emerge in their presence are localized to PF in the same way as Absolutive Preposing: they derail Chain Reduction and force higher-copy spell-out on a par with the Grouping Constraint.

(45) *Prenominal Quantifiers*

a.



b.



3.3 Overt Movement to SPEC,ASPP

In though-complements that lack T^0, it is possible to introduce the viewpoint aspect clitics. I propose that the though-complements that contain them must project up to ASPP.

(46) *Viewpoint Aspect*

a. Mau [$_{\text{ASPP}}$ yari **mo** u-nilai ujiang],
though COMPLETE NOW 1ERG-grade test
'Though now I've graded the tests,'

b. Mau [$_{\text{ASPP}}$ na-baca-ngang **mo** ___ guru buku sanaeke],
though 3ERG-read-APPL NOW teacher book kid
'Though now the teacher has read the books to the kids,'

In the presence of this head, the absolutive DPs that contain prenominal quantifiers are forced to surface in a position that precedes auxiliaries (47a) and raised verbs (47b). In this context, these absolutive DPs are unable to surface in SPEC,*voice*P.

(47) *Movement to the Middle Field*

a. Mau [$_{\text{ASPP}}$ **inggannanna** **ujiang** yari **mo** u-nilai Δ],
though all test COMPLETE NOW 1ERG-grade
'Though now I've graded all the tests,'

b. Mau [$_{\text{ASPP}}$ **inggannanna** **sanaeke** na-ita **mo** guru Δ],
though all kid 3ERG-see NOW teacher
'Though now the teacher has seen all the kids,'

With the right manipulations, we can force regular absolutive DPs into the same linear position. In Mandar, non-subject WH-phrases raise to SPEC,CP (48a). Temporal adjuncts can also front to SPEC,CP from their usual position at the right edge of the *voice*P (48b).

(48) *Adjunct Movement to Spec,CP*

a. [$_{\text{CP}}$ Myapa pai [$_{\Sigma\text{P}}$ mu-sa'ding manini]]?
how 3ABS.YET 2ERG-feel later
'How will you feel later?'

b. [$_{\text{CP}}$ Manini pai [$_{\Sigma\text{P}}$ na mu-ita ___]].
later 3ABS.YET FUTURE 2ERG-see
'Later you'll see it.'

Adjunct movement to SPEC,CP forces head movement from $\text{ASP}^0_{\text{VIEW}}$ to T^0 to C^0. This process bleeds lowering to Σ^0 and forces absolutive agreement and viewpoint aspect to follow the adjuncts and WH-phrases in SPEC,CP, rather than verbs and auxiliaries in Σ^0. The three-word window for the absolutive DP thus begins from the constituent in SPEC,CP.

(49) *Grouping from Spec,CP*

a. {$_\phi$ Pírang i na-báca **búku** } dióngging?
when 3ABS 3ERG-read book yesterday
'When did she read the book yesterday?'

b. {$_\phi$ Pírang i na-báca **búku** } gúru Δ dióngging?
when 3ABS 3ERG-read book teacher yesterday
'When did the teacher read the book yesterday?'

When the absolutive DP can fit into this window from its base position, it is realized there. When it can fit into the window from SPEC,*voice*P but not from its base position, it is realized in SPEC,*voice*P. For instance, in four-word strings that contain a WH-phrase, an absolutive DP, a verb, and an ergative DP, the absolutive DP surfaces after the raised verb in Σ^0 (50a) or the low verb in $voice^0$ (50b).

(50) *Movement to SPEC,VoiceP*

a. {$_\phi$ Pírang i na-báca **búku** } ___ guru Δ dióngging?
when 3ABS 3ERG-read book teacher yesterday
'When did the teacher read the book yesterday?'

b. {$_\phi$ Pírang i yari **búku** na-báca } gúru Δ dióngging?
when 3ABS COMPLETE book 3ERG-read teacher yesterday
'When did the teacher read the book yesterday?'

When the absolutive DP could only fit into the window by surfacing above SPEC,*voice*P, it is realized in a position that follows SPEC,CP. When the absolutive DP and the WH-phrase collectively contain three words, for instance, it appears above raised verbs in Σ^0.

(51) *Movement to SPEC,AspP*

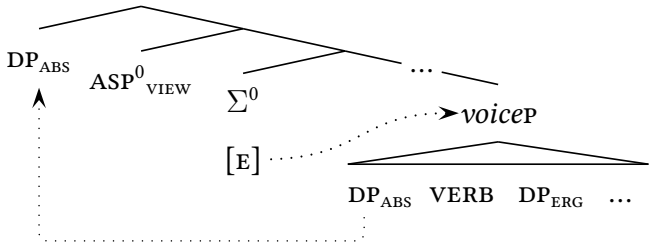
a. {$_\phi$ **Pírang** i **búku linguístik** } na-báca Δ dióngging?
when 3ABS book linguistics 3ERG-read yesterday
'When did she read the linguistics book yesterday?'

b. {$_\phi$ **Jáng sangápa** i **búku** } na-báca Δ dióngging?
time what 3ABS book 3ERG-read yesterday
'What time did she read the book yesterday?'

3.4 Ellipsis and Quantifier Float

The absolutive DP is realized in the same position in contexts of VP-ellipsis (VPE). Mandar has a process that elides the *voice*P, suppressing verbs in *voice*^{0} and all DPs in the *v*P (Brodkin, 2025b, 2026b).[10] It spares all material above the *voice*P: raised verbs and auxiliaries in the extended TP, absolutive agreement and viewpoint aspect, and the high position of the absolutive DP. In auxiliary-initial clauses, it shows the rough syntax in (52).

(52) *Mandar VPE*



This process prevents the absolutive DP from being realized in the *voice*P (53a)-(53b). As a result, when it suppresses the verb, it prevents the absolutive DP from surfacing in the space between the lowest auxiliary in the TP and the final adjuncts to the *voice*P (53c).

(53) *Verb-Phrase Ellipsis*

a. Yari i lamba iKaco' de allo e, tapi…
COMPLETE 3ABS go NAME today but
'Kacho' did go today, but…'

b. Ndang i rua yari Δ dirambongi.
not 3ABS ever COMPLETE in the past
' He never did in the past.'

c. *Ndang i rua yari Δ do asu dirambongi (o).
not 3ABS ever COMPLETE that dog in the past PARTICLE
INTENDED: 'That dog$_{(epithet)}$ never did in the past.'

The only position that can overtly host the absolutive DP in contexts of VPE is SPEC,ASPP: the position that precedes raised verbs and auxiliaries and follows adjuncts in SPEC,CP.[11]

[10] This process shows the canonical properties of VP-ellipsis (VPE; Hankamer & Sag 1976; Lobeck 1987, 1995; Johnson 2001; Goldberg 2005): it occurs in embedded clauses and islands, it proceeds between speakers, and it can pick up antecedents in the discourse. It is also translated naturally into the type of VPE that exists in Indonesian (on which see Fortin 2007a,b and Vander Klok 2016, 2017 on Javanese).

[11] The absolutive DP takes the same position when the verb escapes the VPE site by moving in Σ^0. To

(54) *Absolutive Arguments:* SPEC,ASPP

a. Dota' i lamba iKaco', tapi…
should 3ABS go NAME but
'Kacho' should go, but…'

b. Dirambongi i do asu ndang rua yari Δ o.
in the past 3ABS that dog not ever COMPLETE PARTICLE
'In the past that dog$_{(epithet)}$ never did.'

c. Dirambongi i iCicci' ndang rua yari Δ.
in the past 3ABS NAME not ever COMPLETE
'In the past Chichi' never did.'

We can make a similar argument with a pattern of WH-quantifier float that traces the

---

detect configurations of this type, we can set up an argument for verb-stranding ellipsis (Goldberg 2005; Gribanova 2013; Manetta 2020; on Mandar also Brodkin 2026b). Mandar has elements that appear in the *voice*P and cannot be elided on their own, like pseudo-incorporated adjuncts and directional particles (1a). When these elements appear in the antecedent, they are suppressed and interpreted in contexts of VPE (1b).

(1) *Missing Constituents*

a. Byasa a' lamba-**oto** **dai** diruambongi.
usually 1ABS go-car up in the past
'Usually in the past I would go up by car.'

b. Tapi dite'e mi iKaco' ndang na' Δ.
but nowadays NOW.3ABS NAME not FUTURE
'But nowadays Kaco' won't (go up by car).

When manner adjuncts and directional particles do not overtly appear, it is impossible to interpret them as present in the clauses that contain auxiliaries and overt material in the *voice*P, like the low verb in *voice*^{0} (2a). But in clauses without auxiliaries that host overt verbs in Σ^0, a second reading appears: the "missing" manner adjuncts and directional particles in the antecedent can be interpreted as collectively present beneath the raised verb (2b). This second reading emerges from verb-stranding ellipsis of the *voice*P, and in this context, we can see overt absolutive DPs before the raised verb in Σ^0.

(2) *Verb-Stranding VPE*

a. Ndang i mak-kiring-**oto** **sau** de allo e, tapi dirambongi i rua mak-kiring.
not 3ABS ANTIP-send-car over today but in the past 3ABS once ANTIP-send
LITERALLY: 'She didn't send things by car today, but in the past she once sent things.'

b. Ndang i mak-kiring-**oto** **sau** de allo e, tapi dirambongi i makkiring Δ.
not 3ABS ANTIP-send-car over today but in the past 3ABS ANTIP-send
READING A: 'She didn't send things over by car today, but in the past, she sent things.'
READING B: 'She didn't send things over by car today, but in the past, she did.'
(ONLY INTERPRETATION FOR THE ELLIPSIS SITE: [send things over by car].)

path of the absolutive DP. Mandar has a quantifier *pira* that only appears in the presence of the lexical items *innai* "who," *inna* "which," and *apa* "what." In absolutive WH-questions, it can form a surface constituent with its associate at the edge of the left periphery. But it can also surface in SPEC,ASPP, SPEC,*voice*P, and the base position of the absolutive DP.

(55) *Quantifier Float*

a. [$_{CP}$ WH PIRA … [$_{ASPP}$ _____ … [$_{voiceP}$ _____ … [$_{VP}$ … _____ …]]]]

b. [$_{CP}$ WH _____ … [$_{ASPP}$ PIRA … [$_{voiceP}$ _____ … [$_{VP}$ … _____ …]]]]

c. [$_{CP}$ WH _____ … [$_{ASPP}$ _____ … [$_{voiceP}$ PIRA … [$_{VP}$ … _____ …]]]]

d. [$_{CP}$ WH _____ … [$_{ASPP}$ _____ … [$_{voiceP}$ _____ … [$_{VP}$ … PIRA …]]]]

When *pira* forms a surface constituent with its associated WH-phrase, it falls at the right edge of the DP (55a). Unlike *inggannanna*, the regular word for"all," it cannot associate with regular DPs (55b) or surface in adverbial uses along the clausal spine (55c).

(56) *The Quantifier Pira*

a. [$_{QP}$ Apa **pira**]?
what PIRA
'What all?'

b. [$_{QP}$ *buku **pira** / ***pira** buku]?
book PIRA PIRA book
INTENDED: 'All the books"

c. [**Inggannanna** / ***pira**] monge' a'.
all PIRA sick 1ABS
'I'm all sick.'

In absolutive WH-questions, *pira* can follow the base position of the absolutive DP. This is a type of quantifier float licensed by movement of the absolutive DP to SPEC,*voice*P (Brodkin 2025a; for discussion of stranding under Ā-movement, Sportiche 1988; Shlonsky 1991; Merchant 1996; McCloskey 2000; Bošković 2004; Henry 2012; Zyman 2018; Doliana 2022). When the verb is ditransitive, it places *pira* in the base position of the GOAL (57a); when the verb is antipassive, it places *pira* in the base position of the EXT (57b).

(57) *Stranding in Thematic Positions*

a. Innai yari na-be-ngang [$_{vP}$ iKaco' bunga __ **pira**] digena'?
who COMPLETE 3ERG-give-APPL NAME flower PIRA earlier
'Who all did Kacho' give flowers to earlier?'

b. Innai yari mam-be-ngang [$_{vP}$ __ **pira** bunga na'ibaine] digena'?
who COMPLETE ANTIP-give-APPL PIRA flower girl earlier
INTENDED: 'Who all was giving flowers to girls earlier?'

Pira can also be stranded in SPEC,*voice*P and SPEC,ASPP. When the verb raises to Σ^0, it can precede the EXT in SPEC,*v*P (58a). When the verb remains in *voice*^{0}, it can precede the verb (58b). In either context, it can also surface below temporal adverbs in SPEC,CP (58c).

(58) *Stranding in SPEC,VoiceP*

a. Innai byasa [$_{voiceP}$ __ **pira** na-ita iKaco'] dini?
who usually PIRA 3ERG-see NAME here
'Who all does Kacho' usually see here?'

b. Innai na-ita [$_{voiceP}$ __ **pira** iKaco'] dini?
who 3ERG-see PIRA NAME here
'Who all does Kacho' usually see here?'

c. Innai [$_{CP}$ dirambongi __ **pira** byasa na-ita iKaco' dini]?
who in the past PIRA usually 3ERG-see NAME here
'Who all did Kacho' usually see in the past?'

I submit that both effects emerge at the stage of Chain Reduction. On this analysis, *pira*-float involves Distributed Deletion (Fanselow 2002; Van Urk 2024; also Asinari 2021): *pira* raises as part of the absolutive WH-phrase through SPEC,*voice*P and SPEC,ASPP and it is variably realized in its base position, in SPEC,*voice*P, in SPEC,ASPP, or in SPEC,CP.

(59) *Distributed Deletion*

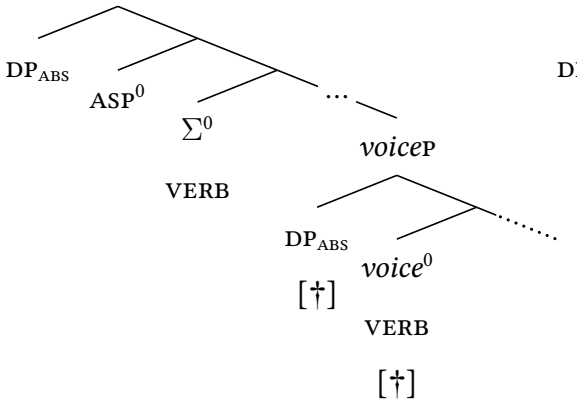
a. [$_{CP}$ WH PIRA] [$_{ASPP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{voiceP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{VP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~]]]]
b. [$_{CP}$ WH ~~PIRA~~ [$_{ASPP}$ ~~WH~~ PIRA] [$_{voiceP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{VP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~]]]]
c. [$_{CP}$ WH ~~PIRA~~ [$_{ASPP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{voiceP}$ ~~WH~~ PIRA] [$_{VP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~]]]]
d. [$_{CP}$ WH ~~PIRA~~ [$_{ASPP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{voiceP}$ ~~WH PIRA~~ [$_{VP}$ ~~WH~~ PIRA]]]]]

In contexts of VPE, the absolutive DP is spelled out in SPEC,ASPP. Adopting the standard view in Distributed Morphology, I take ellipsis to involve a failure of insertion (Wilder, 1997; Bartos, 2000, 2001; Kornfeld & Saab, 2002; Saab, 2008, 2010; Arregi & Nevins, 2014; Merchant, 2015; Abels, 2019). I assume that it is prefigured in the syntax by the assignment of a feature [E] (Merchant, 2001), which falls on the *voice*P in contexts of Mandar VPE. In the morphology, I propose that the nodes contained in constituents bearing [E] are marked with features that block insertion (Brodkin 2026b; see also Müller 2011; Saab 2008, 2010,

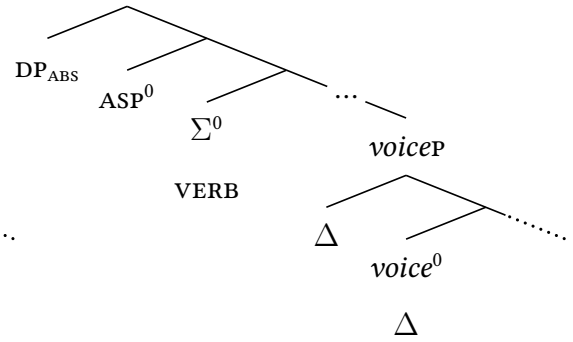
2022; Stigliano 2022b,a). These features will fall on all copies of the absolutive DP in the *voice*P, and as a result, they will force insertion to target the copy of that DP in SPEC,ASPP.

(60) *Escape from Ellipsis*

a. *Morphology*



b. *Insertion*



In the domain of linear order, this analysis derives the alignment between *pira*-float, the realization of the absolutive DP in contexts of ellipsis, and the realization of the absolutive DP in contexts of Absolutive Preposing and prenominal quantification. In the linear positions that can host pira in subject WH-questions and the absolutive DP in contexts of VPE, the absolutive DP can appear in contexts of Preposing and prenominal quantification. In the positions that where the absolutive DP cannot appear in contexts of Preposing and prenominal quantification, pira cannot be stranded and the absolutive DP cannot appear in contexts of VPE. In clauses that host multiple auxiliaries, as a result, it is impossible to strand *pira* or realize the absolutive DP anywhere between SPEC,*voice*P and SPEC,ASPP.

(61) *No Intermediate Positions*

a. Innai [$_{\Sigma P}$ **ndang** (*pira) **rua** (*pira) **yari** na-ita iKaco']]]]?
who not all ever all COMPLETE 3ERG-see NAME
INTENDED: 'Who all did Kacho' never see?'

b. Dota' i lamba iKaco', tapi…
should 3ABS go NAME but
'Kacho' should go, but…'

c. Dirambongi i ndang (*do asu) rua (*do asu) yari Δ (o).
in the past 3ABS not that dog ever that dog COMPLETE PARTICLE
INTENDED: 'In the past, that dog$_{(epithet)}$ never did.'

Linked to the facts of binding and absolute locality, these facts allow us to reinforce and extend two wider hypotheses about the architecture of the grammar. First, in the syntax, at least some types of A-movement must leave copies. This is a PF-level counterpart to a fact of reconstruction (and see also Boeckx 2001; *cf.* Chomsky 1995; Lasnik 1998): constituents that undergo A-movement can be interpreted in their base positions for at least some systems that operate at LF. In English, for instance, Lebeaux 1991 observes that raising to subject allows reconstruction for variable binding beneath experiencer PPs (62a). In Mandar, movement to SPEC,*voice*P also allows reconstruction into the *v*P—allowing variables in the absolutive DP to be bound by a quantified ergative DP (62b).

(62) *Copy-Movement: Parallel Evidence from Reconstruction*

a. His$_i$ mother seems to every boy$_i$ [___ to be a genius]. Lebeaux 1991, 231

b. Mau na-waca panulis nasang buku-na dionging,
though 3ERG-read author every book-her yesterday
'Though every author$_i$ read her$_i$ book yesterday,'

Second, along the PF branch, Copy selection must be able to interact with four types of constraints. The first are surface-level pressures that derail typical patterns of Chain Reduction, like the Grouping Constraint and pressures that force exceptional lower-copy spell-out elsewhere.[12] The second are the constraints that block insertion into nodes marked for ellipsis, which reroute the preference for lowest-copy realization of the absolutive DP. The third are the pressures that govern the realization of individual functional heads, like Mandar prenominal quantifiers. The fourth, at last, are the pressures that enforce a default preference for lower-copy spell-out in certain domains, like the Mandar *voice*P and TP (cf. covert WH-movement: Huang 1982; Richards 1997; Nissenbaum 2000).

[12] As the Grouping Constraint forces exceptional higher-copy spell-out, it provides a mirror image in this respect to Anti-homophony constraints (Bošković, 2002), morphological adjacency constraints (Bobaljik, 2002; Spyropoulos & Revithiadou, 2007; Yuan, 2025), constraints on nuclear stress alignment (Stjepanovic, 1999; Ortega-Santos, 2006; Bianchi, 2019; Seguin, 2025), and purely phonological top-down constraints (Franks, 1998; Bošković, 2001; Harizanov, 2014b). Both types of constraints, in turn, mirror the PF-constraints that have been argued to force Doubling (realization of moved constituents in multiple positions, distinct from the configurations where moved constituents are rendered invisible to reduction by morphological operations like M-merger, though *cf.* Nunes 2004; Nunes & de Quadros 2006; Corver & Nunes 2007; Cheng 2007). These effects have been argued to emerge from the stray-affix filter effects (Landau, 2006; Bjorkman, 2020) and prosodic well-formedness constraints (Kandybowicz, 2015).

4 The Timing of Chain Reduction

The final task of the paper is to identify the derivational stage where Chain Reduction applies. To this end, I will show that Absolutive Preposing is sensitive to the surface constituent structure of the phonology: the Grouping Constraint counts prosodic words and the three-word window is a transparent phonological domain. This type of prosodic structure is built in a parallel and global phonological evaluation that operates over the complete output of the morphosyntax (Selkirk 2009, 2011; see also Elfner 2012, 2015; Elordieta 2015; Bennett *et al.* 2016, 2019; Kalivoda 2018; Ishihara & Kalivoda 2022). As this pressure shapes Chain Reduction, I argue, lexical insertion must also occur in the phonology.

4.1 Prosodic Domains

Phonological strings are transparently parsed into a layered and hierarchical constituent structure that defines the domains for phonotactic restrictions and prosodic constraints in the surface phonology (Selkirk, 1984, 1986; Nespor & Vogel, 1986). This type of constituent structure is built from a series of abstract and universal phonological domains: the metrical categories of mora, syllable, and foot, the interface categories of prosodic word and phonological phrase, and the pragmatic category of the intonational phrase (Itô & Mester, 2007, 2009, 2012, 2013). These domains form the Prosodic Hierarchy in (63).

(63) *The Prosodic Hierarchy*

μ	$>$	σ	$>$	FT	$>$	ω	$>$	ϕ	$>$	ι
MORA		SYLLABLE		FOOT		WORD		PHRASE		INTONATIONAL PHRASE

4.1.1 The Prosodic Word

In Mandar, the prosodic word can be identified from the distribution of stress. The language requires moraic trochees to be built iteratively from the right edge of each word.

(64) *The Prosodic Word*

a. ω — (póle) — ‘come’

b. ω — (lámba) — ‘go’

c. ω — (léleŋ) — ‘go about’

d. ω — (lèp)(páŋ) — ‘stop by’

This diagnostic reveals that words are always built around nouns, adjectives, adverbs, and verbs (65a)-(65b), as well as verbal reduplication (65c) and the antipassive prefix (65d).

(65) *Prosodic Words*

a. [$_\omega$ bállo] [$_\omega$ **mányang**]
palm wine strong
'strong palm wine'

b. [$_\omega$ **máne**] [$_\omega$ na-rúndu]
just 3ERG-drink
'just drank'

c. [$_\omega$ **náru**] [$_\omega$ na-rúndu]
RED 3ERG-drink
'sorta drink'

d. [$_\omega$ **mán**] [$_\omega$ dúndu]
ANTIP drink
'drink'

The same test shows that words are typically not built around prepositions, demonstratives, complementizers, and auxiliaries, which I take to be parsed into recursive words with their associated lexical heads (Peperkamp, 1997; Booij, 1996; Itô & Mester, 2009).

(66) *Non-Words*

a. [$_\omega$ **pole ro** pónna] [$_\omega$ ó]
from that tree there
'From that tree there.'

b. [$_\omega$ mo **ndang** na-rúndu],
though not 3ERG-drink
'Though he didn't have it,'

4.1.2 The Phonological Phrase

The phonological phrase can be detected in Mandar from the distribution of a final tone. This tone falls after all types of phrasal constituents, including maximal DPs and PPs, and it also falls after sequences of lexical heads and head-level adjuncts (67a), norman genitives (67b), the verbal complex (67a), and the auxiliaries that host absolutive agreement (67b).

(67) *The Phonological Phrase*

a. {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ ánde] [$_\omega$ maráras] }^{H}
food spicy
'Spicy food'

b. {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ bírit] [$_\omega$ tàngngalálang] }^{H}
edge road
'Edge of the road'

a. {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ píraŋ] }^{H} i {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ lámba] }^{H}
when 3ABS go
'When did they go?'

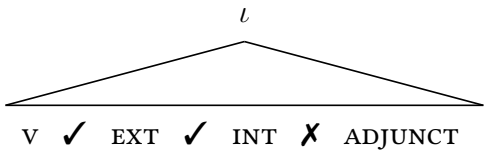
b. {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ púra] }^{H} i {$_\phi$ [$_\omega$ lámba] }^{H}
PAST 3ABS go
'They've gone.'

4.1.3 The Maximal Phonological Phrase

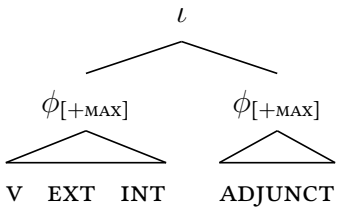
There is a higher level of phonological phrasing that can be detected from restrictions on segmental processes that emerge at specific junctures in the intonational phrase. In Mandar, Brodkin 2025b identifies four processes that show the distribution in (68a): they apply across three-word strings that contain verbs and arguments in the *v*P and are blocked before adjuncts to the *voice*P (for a fifth: Brodkin 2025c). Brodkin 2025b shows that they are keyed to the edges of the MAXIMAL PHONOLOGICAL PHRASE (68b): the type of phonological phrase directly dominated by the intonational phrase (Itô & Mester, 2007, 2012, 2013).

(68) *The Maximal Phonological Phrase*

a. *Restrictions*



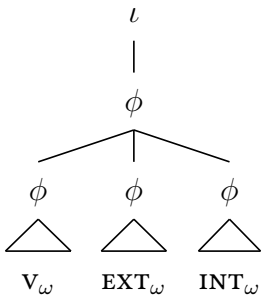
b. *Constituency*



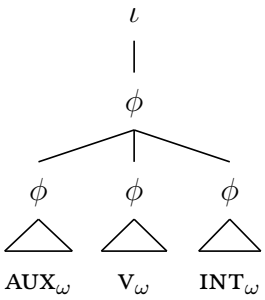
These diagnostics reveal recursive patterns of phonological phrasing (69): the low-level constituents that form minimal phonological phrases are grouped into larger phonological phrases that correspond to functional projections like the CP (Itô & Mester 2007, 2012, 2013; Itô & Mester 2021; Elfner 2012, 2015; Elordieta 2015; Van Handel 2021).

(69) *Recursive Phrasing*

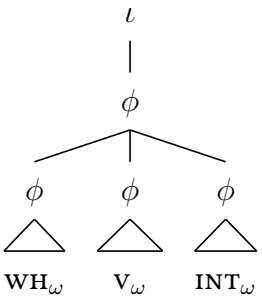
a.



b.



c.



The relevant processes are tabled in (70). The first three are blocked at the right edge of the maximal phonological phrase: Falling-Sonority Coalescence (which reduces strings like /*ai*/ to [*e*]), Rising-Sonority Reduction (which reduces strings like /*ia*/ to [*e*]), and Coda Deletion (which deletes intervocalic /ʔ ŋ/). The fourth is blocked at the left edge: Voiced Obstruent Lenition (which reduces intervocalic /*b d* d͡ʒ *g*/ to [*w* ɹ *j* ɣ]).

(70) *Diagnostics for the Maximal Phrase*

Context	Process	Target	Effect
Word-Final	Falling-Sonority Coalescence	/*ai ae*/	[*e*]
		/*ao au*/	[*o*]
		/*ei oi*/	[*e, o*]
	Rising-Sonority Reduction	/*ie, ue*/	[*e*]
		/*io, uo*/	[*o*]
		/*iu, ui*/	[*u, i*]
		/*ia, ua*/	[*e, o*]
	Intervocalic Coda Deletion	/ʔ/	[Ø]
		/ŋ/	[Ø + nasalization]
Word-Initial	Intervocalic Lenition	/*b d g*/	[*w* ɹ ɣ]
		/d͡ʒ/	[*j*]

The following examples show the distribution of Lenition in three-word strings. In strings of the order V-EXT-INT, it applies at the left edges of the EXT and the INT (71a). In strings of the order V-INT-GOAL-ADJUNCT, it applies at the left edges of the INT and GOAL (71b). It is blocked in each adjunct because adjuncts to the extended VP are systematically excluded from the phonological phrases built around projections along the clausal spine (Brodkin 2025b; also Hale & Selkirk 1987; Truckenbrodt 1995, 1999, Selkirk 2011, fn.38).

(71) *Parsing Verbs + Arguments*

a. {$_{\phi\text{[MAX]}}$ } {$_{\phi\text{[MAX]}}$ }

néte^{H}	pe	**ɣ**úru^{H}	**ɹ**ótor^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
na-itai	pai	guru	dottor	dio
3ERG-look for YET.3ABS		teacher	doctor	there

'The teacher will look for the doctor there.'

b. {$_{\phi\text{[MAX]}}$ } {$_{\phi\text{[MAX]}}$ } {$_{\phi\text{[MAX]}}$ }

nállem^{H}	mi	**w**úku^{H}	**ɣ**úru^{H}	**d**ío^{H}	**d**íteʔe^{H}
na-alli-aŋ	mi	buku	guru	dio	diteʔe
3ERG-buy-APPL NOW.3ABS		book	teacher	there	now

'Now they're buying books for the teacher there.'

The following examples show its distribution in three-word strings that contain WH-phrases and auxiliaries: after those elements, it always applies at the left edge of the V.

(72) *Parsing Auxiliaries + Wh-Phrases*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

jári^{H}	pe	ɹíta^{H}	ɣúru^{H}	**d**ío^{H}	**d**é?^{H}
iari	pai	di-ita	guru	dio	de
COMPLETE	YET.3ABS	2ERG-see	teacher	there	PRT

'You'll see the teacher there, eh?'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

pírap^{H}	pe	ɣumóra^{H}	ɣúru	**d**ío^{H}
piraŋ	pai	gumora	guru	dio
when	YET.3ABS	scream	teacher	there

'When will the teacher scream there?'

4.2 The Grouping Constraint

Outside contexts where the absolutive DP and the host of absolutive agreement collectively contain more than three words, these diagnostics reveal the generalization in (73).

(73) *The Grouping Generalization*

The three-word window that preferentially contains the absolutive DP and the host of absolutive agreement is always a surface-visible maximal phonological phrase.

The following examples show this fact in three-word strings where the absolutive DP is realized in its base position: lenition shows that it always falls into a maximal phonological phrase with the verb (74a), the initial auxiliary (74b), or the constituent in SPEC,CP (74c).

(74) *Grouping from the vP*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

néte^{H}	pe	ɣúru^{H}	ɹótor^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
na-itai	pai	guru	dottor	dio
3ERG-look for	YET.3ABS	teacher	doctor	there

'The teacher will look for the doctor there.'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

jári^{H}	pe	ɹíta^{H}	ɣúru^{H}	**d**ío^{H}	**d**é?^{H}
iari	pai	di-ita	guru	dio	de
COMPLETE	YET.3ABS	2ERG-see	teacher	there	PRT

'You'll see the teacher there, eh?'

c. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

pírap^{H}	pe	**w**émme^{H}	**w**úa^{H}	**d**ío^{H}	**d**íte?e^{H}
piraŋ	pai	bemme?	bua	dio	dite?e
when	YET.3ABS	fall	fruit	there	now

'When will the fruit fall there now?'

Lenition shows the same effect whenever the absolutive DP is realized in SPEC,*voice*P.

(75) *Grouping from SPEC,voiceP*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

néte-néte^{H}	pe	**ɣ**úru^{H}	**d**ótor^{H}		**d**ío^{H}
(σσ)-na-itai	pai	guru	dottor	Δ	dio
RED-3ERG-look for	YET.3ABS	teacher	doctor		there

'The doctor will look around for the teacher there.'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

jári^{H}	pe	**ɣ**umóra^{H}	**ɣ**úru	**d**ío^{H}
jari	pai	gumora	guru	dio
COMPLETE	YET.3ABS	scream	teacher	there

'The teacher will scream there.'

It also reveals the same parse whenever the absolutive DP is realized in SPEC,ASPP.

(76) *Grouping from SPEC,ASPP*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

jás	**sápa**^{H}	pe	**ɣ**úru^{H}	néte	**ɹ**ótor^{H}		**d**ío^{H}
jaŋ	saʔapa	pai	guru	na-itai	dottor	Δ	dio
time	what	YET.3ABS	teacher	3ERG-look for	doctor		there

'What time will the doctor look for the teacher there?'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

pírap^{H}	pe	**ɣ**úru	wásа^{H}	néte	**ɹ**ótor^{H}		**d**ío^{H}
piraŋ	pai	guru	basa	na-itai	dottor	Δ	dio
when	YET.3ABS	teacher	language	3ERG-look for	doctor		there

'When will the doctor look for the language teacher there?'

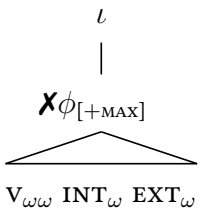
4.2.1 Disruptions to Phrasing

In Mandar, the maximal phonological phrase can only contain up to three prosodic words (Brodkin, 2025b). This constraint derails the expected distribution of maximal phonological phrases in strings that contain more than three words (and for similar effects elsewhere: Nespor & Vogel 1986; Kubozono 1989). In four-word strings that follow the order

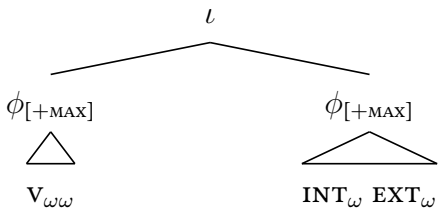
V-EXT-INT, it prevents the TP from forming a single maximal phonological phrase that contains the verb and the two following DPs. When the verb is reduplicated, it thus blocks the integrated parse in (77a) and forces the verb to form its own maximal phonological phrase (77b). When neither the EXT nor the INT is absolutive in this environment, they are parsed into a maximal phonological phrase that corresponds to the VP (Brodkin, 2025b).

(77) *Maximal Weight*

a. *Isomorphic Parse*



b. *Attested Parse*



The following examples show this effect with Lenition. In three-word strings of the order V-EXT-INT, it applies at the left edges of the EXT and the INT (78a). When the verb is reduplicated, however, it is blocked at the left edge of the EXT (78b).

(78) *Evidence for the Weight Constraint*

a. {φ[MAX] } {φ[MAX] }

nállep^{H}	pe	**ɣ**úru^{H}	**w**úku^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
na-alli-aŋ	pai	guru	buku	dio
3ERG-buy-APPL	YET.3ABS	teacher	book	there

'The teacher will buy them books there.'

b. {φ[MAX] } {φ[MAX] } {φ[MAX] }

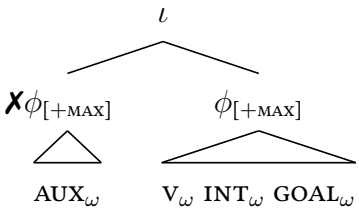
jári^{H}	pe	nálle**ŋ**	gúru	**b**úku^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
jari	pai	na-alli-aŋ	guru	buku	dio
COMPLETE	YET.3ABS	3ERG-buy-APPL	teacher	book	there

'The teacher will buy them books there.'

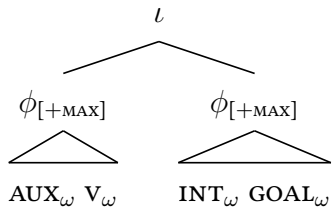
When the weight constraint prevents auxiliaries and WH-phrases from falling into maximal phonological phrases with the *voice*P, they are parsed into maximal phonological phrases that contain the verb and exclude non-absolutive arguments in the *v*P. In four-word strings of order AUX-V-INT-GOAL, as a result, the auxiliary is never put into a maximal phonological phrase on its own (79a). Instead, it falls into a phonological phrase that extends to the verb (79b). When neither the INT nor the GOAL is absolutive, they are parsed into a maximal phonological phrase that corresponds to the *v*P.

(79) *Attraction Effects*

a. *Isomorphic Parse*



b. *Attraction*



The following examples show this effect with High Vowel Reduction. In three-word strings of the order V-INT-GOAL, this process applies at the right edge of the antipassive verb *mallianŋ* and reduces it to [*malleŋ*] (80a). In four word strings, it is blocked and the verb takes the form [*mallianŋ*] when it follows an auxiliary or a WH-phrase (80b).

(80) *Preverbal Material*

a. {ϕ[MAX] } {ϕ[MAX] }

mállep^{H}	pe	**w**úku^{H}	**ɣ**úru^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
maʔ-alli-aŋ	pai	buku	guru	dio
ANTIP-buy-APPL YET.3ABS		book	teacher	there

'They'll buy teachers books there.'

b. {ϕ[MAX] } {ϕ[MAX] } {ϕ[MAX] }

jári^{H}	pe	mall**íam**	búku^{H}	**ɣ**úru	**d**ío^{H}
jari	pai	maʔ-alli-aŋ	buku	guru	dio
COMPLETE YET.3ABS		ANTIP-buy-APPL	book	teacher	there

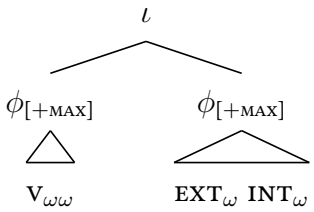
'They'll buy teachers books there.'

4.2.2 Grouping Revised

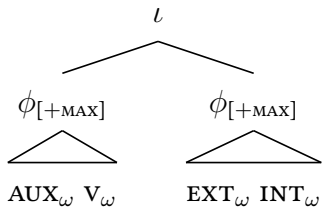
These constraints can prevent arguments from falling into maximal phonological phrases with the hosts of absolutive agreement from their base positions. In strings of the order V-EXT-INT, for instance, the base position of the INT falls outside of this maximal phonological phrase when we reduplicate the verb (81a) or add an auxiliary (81b).

(81) *Exclusion Effects*

a.



b.



In four-word strings of this type, the INT is only realized in its base position when it is not absolutive (82a). When it is, it is realized in SPEC,*voice*P and transparently parsed into a maximal phonological phrase with the host of absolutive agreement 82b).

(82) *Grouping and SPEC,VoiceP*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

nawéŋap^{H}	pe	**ɣúru**^{H}	**b**úku^{H}	wása^{H}	**d**ío^{H}
na-be-ngang	pai	guru	buku	basa	dio
3ERG-give-APPL YET.3ABS		teacher	book	language	there

'The teacher will give them the language book here.'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ }

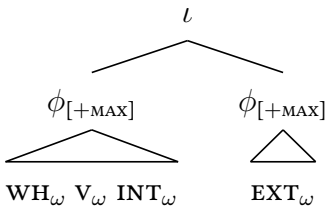
néte^{H}	pe	**w**úku^{H}	**w**ása^{H}	**gúru**^{H}		**d**ío^{H}
na-itai	pai	buku	basa	guru	Δ	dio
3ERG-look for YET.3ABS		book	language	teacher		there

'The teacher will look for the language book there.'

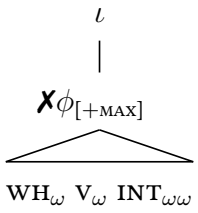
The weight constraint can also prevent SPEC,*voice*P from fitting into the maximal phonological phrases that begin with WH-phrases in SPEC,CP. In four-word strings of the underlying order WH-VERB-EXT-INT, it allows the absolutive INT to fit into that maximal phonological phrase from SPEC,*voice*P (83a). But in four-word strings of the underlying order WH-VERB-INT, it prevents the absolutive INT from falling into that maximal phonological phrase from that position when it contains two words (83b).

(83) *Grouping Problems from SPEC,VoiceP*

a. *Possible Grouping*



b. *Impossible Grouping*



In the first context, the INT is always realized in SPEC,*voice*P when it is the absolutive DP (84a). In the second, it is necessarily realized in SPEC,ASPP and transparently parsed into the maximal phonological phrase that contains the WH-phrase in SPEC,CP (84b).

(84) *Grouping and SPEC,ASPP*

a. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ **pírap**^{H} piraŋ when | pe pai YET.3ABS | néte na-itai 3ERG-look for | **ɣ**úru guru teacher } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ **d**ótor^{H} dottor doctor } Δ {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ **d**ío^{H} dio there }

'When will the doctor look for the teacher there?'

b. {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ **pírap**^{H} piraŋ when | pe pai YET.3ABS | **ɣ**úru guru teacher | wása^{H} basa language } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ néte na-itai 3ERG-look for | **ɹ**ótor^{H} dottor doctor } {$_{\phi[\text{MAX}]}$ Δ **d**ío^{H} dio there }

'When will the doctor look for the language teacher there?'

4.3 Chain Reduction Revised

These results allow us to revise our description of Absolutive Preposing in (24) to (85).

(85) *Absolutive Preposing* (Final Version)
The absolutive DP is realized in the lowest possible syntactic position that lets it fit into a maximal phonological phrase with the host of absolutive agreement.

To capture this effect, I propose that Chain Reduction in the Mandar TP is guided by the ranked and violable constraint in (86). This is a constraint that mobilizes the output constituent structure of the phonology to reflect an input relationship of the morphosyntax. It belongs to a family of constraints that mobilize prosodic constituency to reflect input relationships of agreement (on which see Deguchi & Kitagawa 2002; Ishihara 2003; Hirotani 2005; Smith 2005; for discussion, Smith 2013, 2014; Richards 2016; Branan 2018).

(86) *The Grouping Constraint (Final Version)*
The absolutive DP cannot fall outside of the maximal phonological phrase that contains the exponent of absolutive agreement.

Absolutive Preposing is forced by the interaction of this constraint with two other pressures at the syntax-prosody interface. The first is the pressure for lowest-copy spell-out (87a), which favors low realization of the absolutive DP. The second is the maximal weight constraint (87b), which prevents the phonological phrase that contains absolutive agreement from being extended indefinitely toward the base position of the absolutive DP.

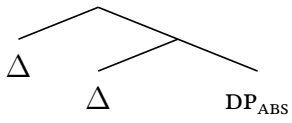
(87) *The Other Constraints*

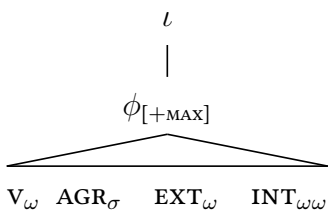
a. *Lowest*
Realize the lowest possible copy of the absolutive DP.

b. *Maximal Ternarity*
The maximal phonological phrase cannot contain more than three words.

The ranking of MAXIMAL TERNARITY > GROUPING and GROUPING > LOWEST delivers three key results. First, LOWEST will be fully satisfied when the regular patterns of syntax-prosody mapping should build a maximal phonological phrase that stretches from the host of absolutive agreement to the base position of the absolutive DP.

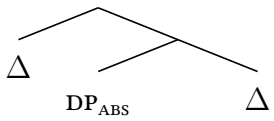
(88) *Low Spell-Out*

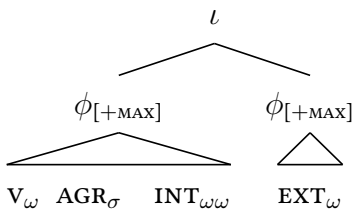
a.


b.


Second, LOWEST will be violated to the minimum possible degree—resulting in the lowest possible spell-out of the absolutive DP—whenever MAXIMAL TERNARITY prevents the system of syntax-prosody mapping from building maximal phonological phrases from the host of absolutive agreement to later positions of the absolutive DP.

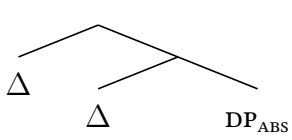
(89) *Absolutive Preposing*

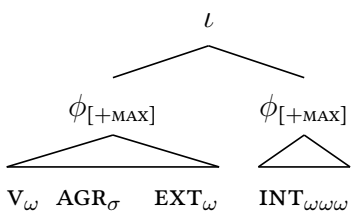
a.


b.


Third, LOWEST will be fully satisfied when MAXIMAL TERNARITY makes it impossible to satisfy the Grouping Constraint—forcing lowest-copy spell out whenever the absolutive DP and the host of absolutive agreement collectively contain three or more words.

(90) *Giving Up*

a. 

b. 

The result is an analysis that places Absolutive Preposing in a class with other patterns of Chain Reduction that interact with output constraints. The most familiar of these emerges in South Slavic in response to a constraint that bans monosyllabic pronouns and auxiliaries at the left edge of the intonational phrase. In Serbo-Croatian, Franks 1998; Franks & King 2000 and Bošković 2001 argue that this prosodic restriction can force lower-copy spell-out: the pronouns and auxiliaries raise through several positions and undergo insertion in the highest one that is non-initial in the intonational phrase.

(91) *Output Constraints Shape Chain Reduction*

a. Predstavio sam mu se.
introduced am to him REFLEXIVE
'I introduced myself to him.' Franks & King 2000 (reglossed)

b. [$_{FP}$ ~~SAM MU~~ ~~SE~~ [Predstavio sam mu se [~~PREDSTAVIO~~]]]
am to him REFLEXIVE introduced
'I introduced myself to him.' Franks & King 2000 (reglossed)

In wider perspective, this result allows us to link our theory of Chain Reduction to the wider class of phenomena that involve interaction between exponence and output constraints. The closest parallels in this domain lie with ellipsis, where output constraints can force insertion into terminal nodes marked for suppression in the morphosyntax (Bennett *et al.*, 2019; Brodkin, 2026b). Another link emerges around suspended exponence: output constraints seem to block insertion into terminal nodes that are matched with exponents in the morphology (Henderson, 2012; Aissen, 2017; Brodkin, 2026c). A final parallel emerges around allomorphy, where output constraints have been argued to guide exponent selection in a broad range of ways (Wolf 2007, 2008; Nevins 2011; Svenonius 2013; Deal & Wolf 2017; Brodkin 2025c): to resolve constraints on foot structure (Mester, 1994; Drachman *et al.*, 1995; Kager, 1996; Dolbey, 1997; Booij, 1998; González, 2005; Bennett, 2017), hiatus (Tranel, 1996; Perlmutter, 1998; Klein, 2003; Bonet *et al.*, 2007; Mascaró, 2007; Suh, 2008), and top-down prosodic alignment (McCarthy, 2012; Brodkin, 2025c).

5 Conclusion

Beyond the narrow arena of Chain Reduction, the arc of our investigation leads us toward three additional results. The first surrounds the analysis of Mandar syntax in (92), which draws the absolutive DP to the edge of the clause-internal phase and then up into the middle field. The linear evidence for these two steps allows us to reinforce two wider hypotheses about the systems that give rise to High Absolutive configurations. First, it must be possible for absolutive arguments to undergo regular steps of movement to dedicated A-positions in the extended TP, tightening the parallel with nominative subjects in systems of this type. Second, it must be possible for them to pass through the edge of the clause-internal phase in systems of this type—suggesting that that position may play a key role in the derivation of High Absolutive configurations.

(92) *Clausal Syntax*

a.	SYNTAX:	$[_{TP}$	DP_{ABS}	v	$[_{voiceP}$	DP_{ABS}	DP_{ERG}	$[_{voiceP}$	DP_{ABS}	$]\ ]\ ].$
b.	USUAL PF:	$[_{TP}$	Δ	v	$[_{voiceP}$	Δ	DP_{ERG}	$[_{voiceP}$	DP_{ABS}	$]\ ]\ ].$
c.	SPECIAL PF:	$[_{TP}$	DP_{ABS}	v	$[_{voiceP}$	Δ	DP_{ERG}	$[_{voiceP}$	Δ	$]\ ]\ ].$

The second surrounds pressures like the Grouping Constraint, which mobilize surface prosodic constituency to reflect input relationships of morphosyntactic agreement. These constraints are distinct from the standard faithfulness constraints of Match Theory, which demand a more straightforward input-output isomorphism between syntactic and prosodic domains. In wider perspective, however, they fit together with a family of pressures that have been argued to reroute prosodic structure-building to reinstantiate input relationships of many further types, from C-command (Kalivoda, 2018) and selection (Clemens, 2016, 2019) to adjunction (Brodkin, 2025b). To the extent that this investigation is on the right track, then, it provides an additional argument that these pressures exist.

(93) *The Grouping Constraint (Repeated)*
The absolutive DP cannot fall outside of the maximal phonological phrase that contains the exponent of absolutive agreement.

The third surrounds the architecture of prosodic structure-building along the PF branch. To capture the facts of Absolutive Preposing, I have assumed that prosodic structure is built in the parallel, global, and surface-oriented phonological evaluation of Match Theory. This architectural perspective contrasts with two alternatives that posit some degree

of cyclicity in the construction of prosodic domains. The first is the paradigm of CYCLIC SPELL-OUT, which assumes that prosodic domains are built and readjusted as complex syntactic objects are spelled out piece-by-piece (for various proposals, see Dobashi 2004, 2010; Ishihara 2007; Adger 2007; Pak 2008; Newell 2009; Kahnemuyipour 2009). The second is the framework of CONTIGUITY THEORY, which takes prosodic structure-building to proceed in a derivational fashion and allows it to directly influence the syntax (Richards 2016, 2020; see also Richards 2010). In the domain of Chain Reduction, these frameworks diverge around at least the prediction in (94): if there is any type of cyclicity to prosodic structure-building, it should be possible for prosodically conditioned effects to be opaque.

(94) *Predictions about Opacity*

FRAMEWORK	CYCLICITY	OPACITY
MATCH THEORY	✗	✗
CYCLIC SPELL-OUT	✓	✓
CONTIGUITY THEORY	✓	✓

Outside the arena of Chain Reduction, there is little evidence in the phrasal phonology for opacity of any type (Kiparsky 1985; Booij & Rubach 1987). In the domain of prosodic structure-building, for instance, Cheng & Downing 2016 establish that there is no evidence for cyclicity to be drawn from the distribution of regular phonological phenomena that are sensitive to prosodic phrasing in Chichewa, Kinyambo, Luganda, and Zulu. In Mandar, in the same vein, a reviewer notes that the segmental processes that are sensitive to maximal phonological phrasing seem to afford no special status to the content of the *voice*P phase. To this body of observations we can add one final fact: to derive Absolutive Preposing, it is sufficient to refer to the transparently visible prosodic structure of the surface phonology. In this system of Chain Reduction, in other words, there is no evidence for opacity of any type: the Grouping Constraint is transparently enforced in the surface phonology and the absolutive DP is only spelled out high when that allows it to visibly satisfy that constraint. I leave it to future work to establish whether similar patterns of prosodically conditioned Chain Reduction are ever able to deviate from this surface-oriented shape.

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